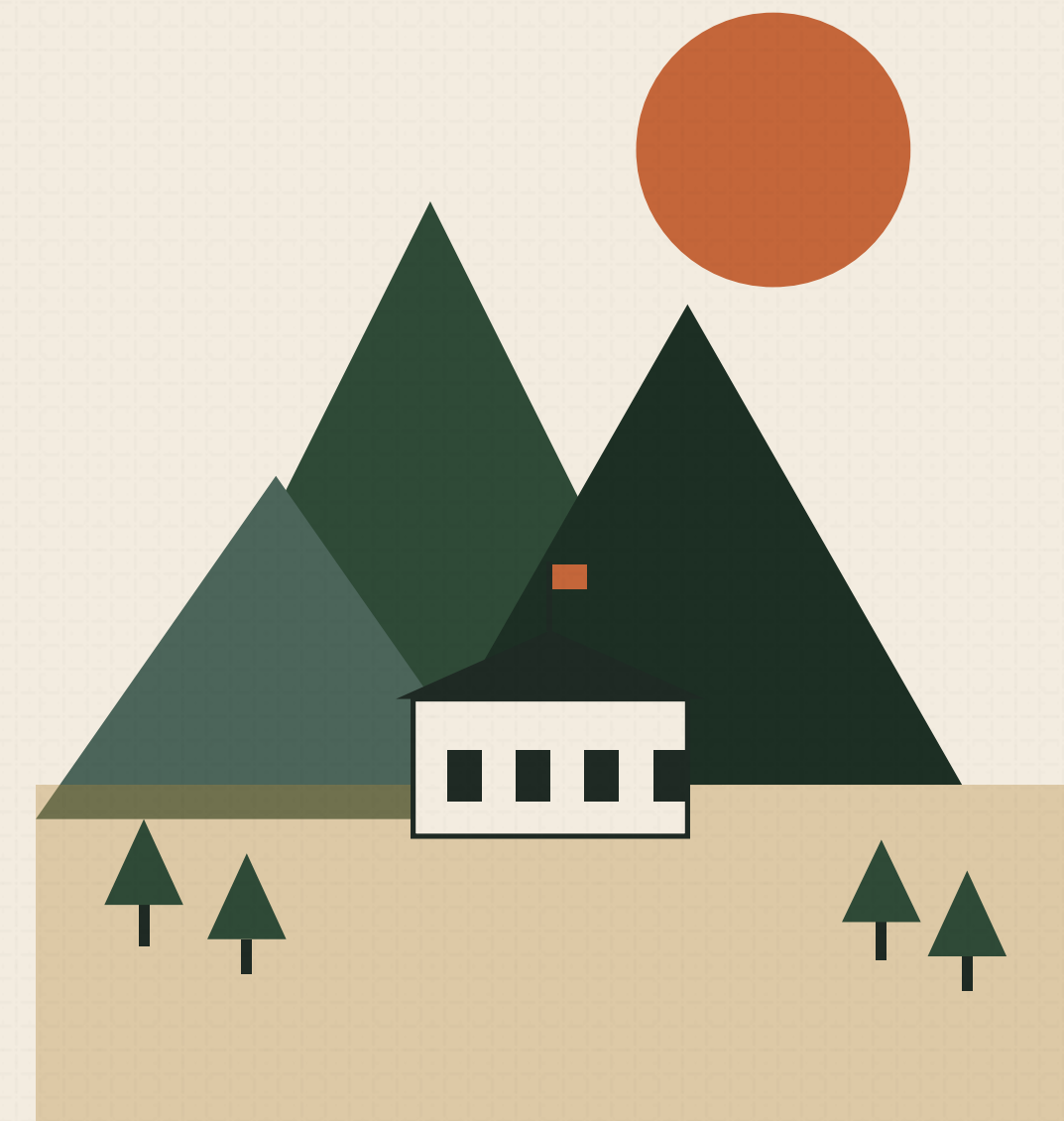


A 25-YEAR INITIATIVE ・ 二十五年計画

A modest plan for a small village in the *mountains*.

奈良県御杖村
森林・分散型エネルギー・地域所
有のデータセンター

FOREST ・ EV POWER ・ AI



ROB OUDENDIJK ・ YR-DESIGN / SAFECAST

MITSUE VILLAGE · 奈良県御杖村

One closed school.
One *tired forest*.
One short list of
ideas.

Mitsue is a mountain village in Nara Prefecture. The elementary school closed. The cedar plantations around it are old and unmanaged. The grid is fragile. None of this is unusual in rural Japan — that's the whole point.

If a small, careful intervention works here, it should be copy-pasteable into a thousand other villages with the same pattern.

COORDINATES · 座標

34.4194° N
136.0511° E

POPULATION

≈ 1,400

FOREST COVER

≈ 93%

SCHOOL CLOSED

2020

PROJECT HORIZON

25 yr

RURAL REVITALIZATION, BUT QUIETLY.

Four expensive problems that turn out to be *cheaper together.*

四つの構造的圧力、ひとつの農村型解答

01 · ENERGY



EV cars are coming.

≈ 10 years until most Japanese passenger vehicles are electric. Rural grids need new distributed generation. Extension is slow and expensive.

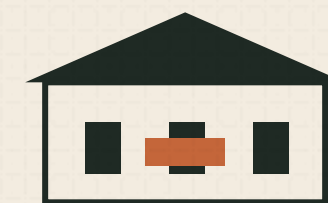
02 · FOREST



Cedar is a liability.

Aged sugi plantations: pollen burden, biodiversity loss, landslide risk. Replacing them with native broadleaf converts a liability into a living forest.

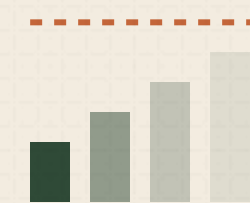
03 · STRANDED



The school just sits there.

Closed schools cost shrinking municipalities money to maintain. Productive reuse turns them into community anchors.

04 · DIGITAL



Rural compute is thin.

Broadband and edge-compute capacity lag urban Japan. A small data center closes both gaps at once, on local power.

Forest. Power. Compute. *One ledger.*

森林再生・分散型再生可能エネルギー・地域所有のデータセンター — 一つの台帳で。

I Forest restoration

Aged cedar → native broadleaf, on the ecological clock.

II Local energy + EV

Local solar + storage + EV chargers on one bus.
Blackout resilience built in.

III Edge data center

Closed school, repurposed. Small enough that the village owns it.

We feed the bears, so the bears *stop* *visiting*.

Phased replacement of aged sugi (cedar) plantations with native broadleaf — oak, chestnut, konara. Done with local landowners and the Forestry Agency. The 25-year arc is the ecological clock, not the funding cycle.

Broadleaf trees produce acorns and nuts that sustain deer, wild boar, and bear through winter. When the forest feeds them, they stay in the forest — and out of the village vegetable patch.

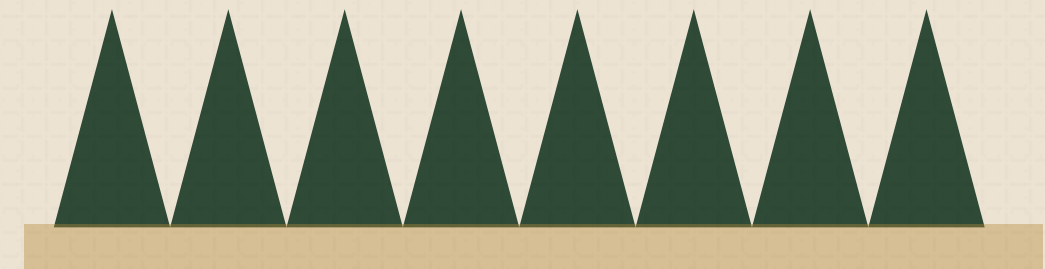
POLLEN
↓ down

LANDSLIDE RISK
↓ down

NATIVE CANOPY
↑ up

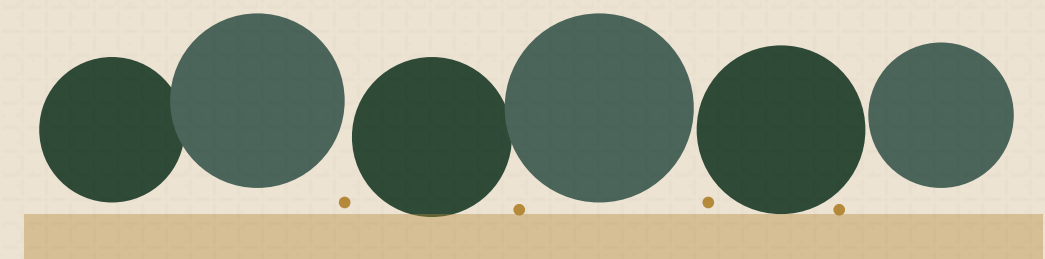
05 / 11

BEFORE · 杉人工林



Monoculture. Pollen. Quiet ground.

AFTER · 在来広葉樹

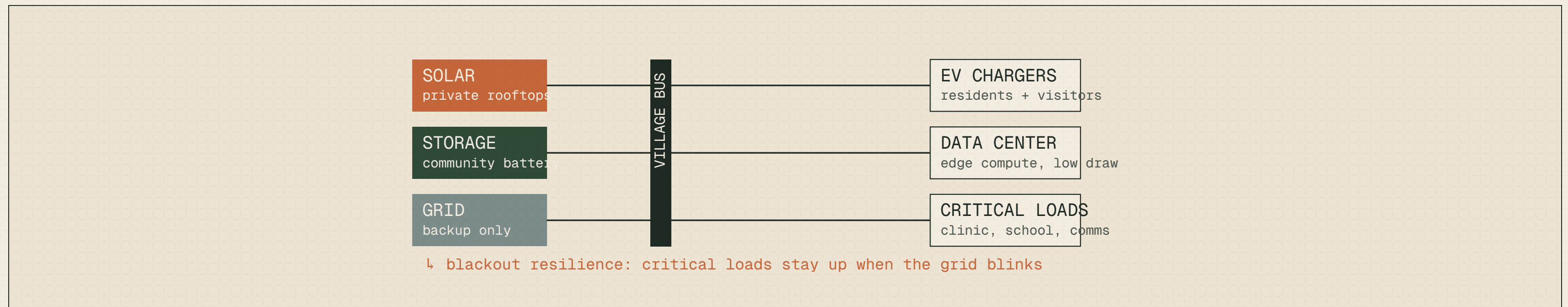


Mixed canopy. Acorns. Deer eats here, not your daikon.

SUGI → BROADLEAF · 25-YEAR CYCLE · WILDLIFE BALANCE

Local sun. Local chargers. *Lights stay on* when the grid blinks.

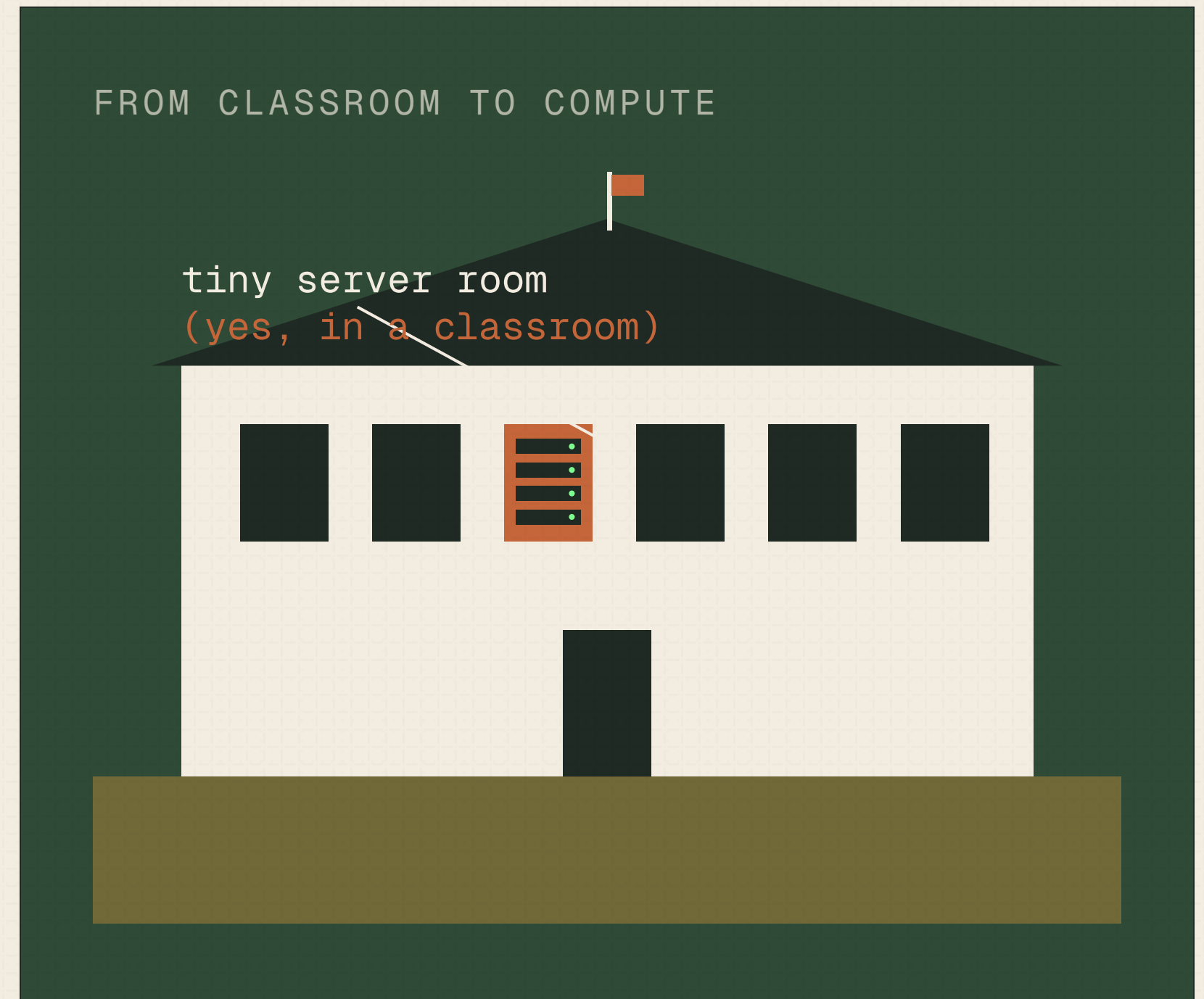
Privately-owned village solar feeds a shared bus, with a community battery for the dark hours and the grid as backup. EV chargers tie to local generation instead of waiting on grid extension. On-site generation keeps the school, the clinic, and emergency facilities running through blackouts — and aging rural distribution lines make those a growing risk.



A data center that goes to *elementary school.*

The closed Mitsue Elementary School building, repurposed as a small, energy-efficient edge-compute facility — powered entirely by locally generated renewable energy.

Sized for accountability, not hyperscale economics. Small enough that the village owns it, audits it, and can explain what it does. Heat re-use warms greenhouses and community buildings. Designed to be replicated by other depopulating municipalities — the blueprint is open.



SCALE

Edge

07 / 11

POWER

100% local

OWNER

The village

EDGE COMPUTE · HEAT RE-USE · REPLICABLE · PROGRESS + SUSTAINABILITY

The win doesn't depend on the data center being a *commercial hit*.

Most benefits accrue to the village whether the compute side breaks even or not. That's the design.

COMMUNITY

- ↳ Paid forestry work, year-round
- ↳ EV charging for residents & visitors
- ↳ The school stops bleeding money
- ↳ Blackout-resilient clinic + comms
- ↳ Modest, accountable, village-owned

ENVIRONMENT

- ↳ Native broadleaf returns at scale
- ↳ Cedar pollen burden goes down
- ↳ Wildlife pressure on farms drops
- ↳ Landslide risk reduces with age
- ↳ 100% local renewable energy mix

BEYOND MITSUE

- ↳ Methods + data published openly
- ↳ A replicable rural template
- ↳ CC-BY documents, open licences
- ↳ Designed to be copied, not franchised
- ↳ A bridge to small-scale fusion era

PHASE 0 · PRE-FOUNDATION · 準備期

Quiet on purpose. *No press,* no website launch, no founder hoodies.

Phase 0 is local trust-building, founding-team formation, and clean drafting of the charter. Self-funded, ¥0–0.5M. The work that matters right now is meetings, not announcements.

ADVISORY COMMITMENTS

Joi Ito

Former Director, MIT Media Lab

Ray Ozzie

Software pioneer · ex-Microsoft CSA

✓ COMPLETED

- Initial meeting with Vice Mayor of Mitsue (late 2025)
- Initial meeting with local forestry group (early 2026)
- Founding charter + implementation plan drafted
- Phase / funding-gate flowchart published
- Advisory commitments: Joi Ito, Ray Ozzie

→ IN PROGRESS

- Identifying a Japanese co-founder with rural credibility
- Scheduling a formal meeting with the Village Mayor
- Drafting bylaws for a 一般社団法人
- Engaging a 行政書士 (administrative scrivener) in Nara

○ NEXT 30 DAYS

- Approach candidate Japanese co-founder
- Hold informal meeting with the Village Mayor
- Initial consultations with administrative scriveners
- Finalise the two-page bilingual charter

Five phases.

Four *real* funding gates.

Each gate is a checkpoint. Miss one and we hold and re-pitch — we don't accelerate into an under-resourced phase.
The funding stack has five layers, deliberately, so no single source can stall the project early.



FIVE-LAYER FUNDING STACK · YEAR-3 TARGET ≈ ¥134M

Layer	Source	Yr 1	Yr 3
L1	Founder / private	¥3M	¥1M
L2	Government grants	¥5M	¥80M
L3	Foundations	¥3M	¥20M
L4	Corporate partners	¥0	¥30M
L5	Operating revenue	¥0	¥3M
Σ	Illustrative total	¥11M	¥134M

SIX OPERATING PRINCIPLES

- I. Local first

III. Patient, long-term

V. Modest in scale
- II. Open & transparent

IV. Replicable

VI. Non-partisan

IF YOUR TIME HORIZON MATCHES OURS...

We're looking for
patient capital,
honest critique,
and a few
good neighbors.

WHAT HELPS RIGHT NOW

- ↳ Introductions: Japanese co-founders with rural credibility
- ↳ Advisors: forestry, edge compute, Japanese nonprofit law
- ↳ Patient funders for Phase 1 (¥3–8M)
- ↳ Honest critique — tell us where the thesis is wrong

WHERE TO READ MORE

mitsue.it
codeberg.org / YR-Design / mitsue-ai-data-center
info@mitsue.it

PROJECT LEAD

Rob Oudendijk

YR-Design · Safecast · Mitsue, Nara